A similar claim was forcefully made by amateur historian P.N. Oak throughout much of the 20th century about the Taj Mahal. He argued that the building was literally a Hindu palace-temple that was converted by Shah Jahan into a tomb, and that an anti-Hindu conspiracy prevented him from opening sealed tombs and revealing that they were full of Hindu relics. He went even further by arguing that every single Muslim building in India was in fact a Hindu building that had been converted to Muslim use, while also asserting that both Islam and Christianity were perverted forms of Hinduism and that both the Vatican and Westminster Abbey were also Hindu temples[47]. While Oak's writing has no basis in architectural or archival history, it has been taken up by members of the same anti-Muslim movement and continues to resurface regularly since his death in 2007, with modern claims that Shah Jahan was actually a closet Hindu[48]. In recent years, a North American Hindu convert named Stephen Knapp has taken up the issue of the Taj as a "Vedic temple," making his argument by cherry-picking images of the Taj's decorations, emphasizing the Hindu elements of the architecture, and completely ignoring the building's style, history and overall decor[49]. It must be emphasized by any calm examiner of the building that these theories hold no water and are malicious attempts to undermine the already vulnerable position of India's Muslims and legitimize both the destruction of their heritage and physical attacks against them.

Of course, not all modern manipulations of the Taj have been so troubling. The site has even been host to occasional bouts of playfulness. In 2000, PC Sorcar Jr., an Indian stage magician, created an illusion during which the Taj disappeared from view, delighting visitors. [50]

Alongside these debates and symbolic uses, the world status of the Taj Mahal has only been strengthened and confirmed in recent years. In 1983, the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) recognized the Taj Mahal as part of its list of World Heritage Sites, stating that it represents "a masterpiece of human creative genius." While the list was created in 1972, India only began submitting sites to it in 1983, so it was amongst the first crop of Indian listees (alongside the nearby Agra Fort, the Ellora Caves and the Ajanta Caves).[51] A less august honor was the opening of the Trump Taj Mahal casino in Atlantic City New Jersey in 1990[52], the Taj Mahal Palace and Tower in Mumbai in 1903, and the Taj Mahal Hotel in